THE COMPLETE 0 TO 100 BEGINNER GUIDE

AI VIDEO GENERATION.

Create cinematic AI videos without cameras, actors or expensive equipment. One tool, one workflow, one finished reel by the end of this guide.

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Tool access and free plans verified on 28 July 2026. Credits, models and prices may change.

What's Inside

Sixteen short sections. Read in order the first time. Then use it as a reference.

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> **HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE**
>
> Do not read everything and generate nothing. Read sections 1 to 6. Then open Google Flow and make one clip today. Come back for the rest when you need it.

SECTION 01

What is AI video generation?

AI video generation lets you create videos by giving an AI one of these inputs:

- A written prompt
- A starting image
- A starting and ending frame
- Reference images of a character, product or location
- An existing video that you want to modify

You do not need a professional camera, actors, locations or advanced editing knowledge.

> **REALITY CHECK**
>
> AI video generation is not usually about entering one prompt and receiving a perfect 30-second video. Most AI tools are best at generating short clips of around 4 to 10 seconds. Longer videos are created by generating multiple shots and joining them together.

The professional workflow

Idea → Shot list → Reference images → Short AI clips → Voice and sound → Editing → Final export

Every section of this guide covers one part of this pipeline. If a video ever feels stuck, find which stage failed and fix only that stage.

SECTION 02

The five types of AI video generation

Every AI video tool uses one or more of these five methods. Learn the names first. The rest of the guide uses them constantly.

1. Text to Video

You describe a scene using text and the AI creates the complete video.

Example: "A young entrepreneur working alone in a dark office at midnight, laptop light illuminating his face, slow cinematic camera push-in, realistic lighting, shallow depth of field, vertical video."

Best for: cinematic scenes, reel hooks, concept videos, fantasy visuals, establishing shots.

2. Image to Video BEST FOR BEGINNERS

You upload an image and ask the AI to animate it.

Best for: keeping a person's appearance, product advertisements, bringing photographs to life, character consistency, controlling the composition.

For most beginners, image to video gives more predictable results than text to video. You have already decided what the first frame looks like.

3. Frames to Video

You provide a starting image and an ending image. The AI creates the movement between them.

Best for: before and after transitions, outfit changes, location transformations, product reveals, smooth scene transitions.

4. Reference or Ingredients to Video

You upload separate references for the character, product, object and visual style. The AI combines them into one scene.

Best for: advertisements, recurring characters, branded content, short films, product-focused videos.

Google Flow calls this workflow Ingredients to Video. It can use multiple images to control the characters, objects and style of a scene.

5. Video to Video

You upload an existing video and ask the AI to modify its style, subject, background, lighting or movement.

Best for: changing the visual style, replacing backgrounds, creating VFX, turning real footage into animation, keeping the exact movement of a person.

SECTION 03

The best free beginner workflow

You can start without paying for any tool.

THE ₹0 AI VIDEO STACK

Planning	ChatGPT or Gemini
Image creation	Gemini, Adobe Firefly or another free image generator
Video generation	Google Flow
Editing	VN Editor (mobile) or DaVinci Resolve (desktop)
Voice	Your own recorded voice or the editor's text-to-speech
Music	Royalty-free music or licensed AI-generated music

Google Flow free credits, explained

- Google currently gives non-subscribers **50 free Flow credits per day**.
- Veo 3.1 **Lite** costs 10 credits per generation for non-Ultra users. That means up to five Lite generations per day.
- Veo 3.1 **Fast** costs 20 credits. **Quality** costs 100 credits per generation.
- Unused free credits do not roll over.

> **IMPORTANT**
>
> Google charges credits per generated video, not necessarily per prompt. One request may sometimes return multiple generations and use credits for each output. Always check the cost beside the model before generating.

SECTION 04

Google Flow: complete beginner tutorial

Nine steps. Follow them in order for your first clip.

1 Decide what you are creating

Do not open the tool before deciding the purpose of the video. Choose one: a three-second reel hook, a cinematic transition, a product advertisement, a story scene, a music visual, a faceless content clip, or a background for a talking-head reel.

Your first project should be **one simple shot**, not a complete film.

2 Write the shot in one sentence

Bad: "Make a cool AI video."

Better: "A university student opens a laptop in a library and a glowing futuristic city rises from the screen."

This sentence becomes the foundation of your prompt.

3 Choose the generation method

- **Text to Video** when you are experimenting and do not need an exact character.
- **Image to Video** when the character, product or composition matters.
- **Frames to Video** when you want a controlled transformation.
- **Ingredients to Video** when you have separate references for a character, product or style.

4 Select the correct aspect ratio

- **9:16** for Instagram Reels, TikTok and YouTube Shorts
- **16:9** for YouTube videos, advertisements and presentations
- **1:1** for square social posts
- **4:5** for Instagram feed posts

For reels, always generate vertically when the tool supports it. Cropping a landscape video into vertical format can remove important subjects and reduce quality.

5 Start with the cheapest model

Use Veo 3.1 Lite while testing your prompt. Only move to Fast or Quality when the concept is working, the framing is correct, the character looks right, the movement is understandable and you know the clip will be used.

Do not spend expensive credits trying to discover your idea.

6 Enter a detailed prompt

Shot type + Subject + Action + Environment + Camera + Lighting + Style + Mood + Format + Restrictions

Example: "Close-up shot of a university student staring at his laptop in shock as hundreds of glowing AI tools burst out of the screen, modern college library, slow camera push-in, dramatic blue and yellow lighting, realistic cinematic style, high contrast, energetic and surprising mood, vertical 9:16 composition, no text, no logos, no watermark."

7 Generate multiple variations

The first generation is rarely the final answer. When reviewing a result, check:

- Is the subject clearly visible?
- Does the action make sense?
- Is the camera movement smooth?
- Are the hands and face usable?
- Does the video match the intended mood?
- Is there enough empty space for captions?
- Can the first second stop someone from scrolling?

Change only one or two parts of the prompt during each retry. This helps you understand what caused the improvement.

8 Extend or create the next shot

Do not ask the model to perform five different actions in one clip.

Instead of: "He enters the room, opens the laptop, sees a robot, runs outside and enters a flying car."

Create separate shots: He enters the room. He opens the laptop. A robot appears behind him. He reacts and runs. He enters the flying car.

Generate each shot separately and combine them during editing.

9 Download only the best generations

Save the final video, the prompt, the reference images, the model used, the aspect ratio, and any seed or generation settings available.

ONE FOLDER PER PROJECT

Project Name → References · Prompts · Raw generations · Selected clips · Audio · Final exports

SECTION 05

The AI video prompt formula

A strong video prompt answers eight questions. Use this page as your writing checklist.

1. What is the shot?

Extreme close-up · Close-up · Medium shot · Wide shot · Aerial shot · Point-of-view shot · Over-the-shoulder shot · Tracking shot

2. Who or what is visible?

Be specific.

Weak: "A man."
Strong: "A 21-year-old Indian university student with short black hair, wearing an olive-green T-shirt and carrying a black backpack."

3. What is happening?

Use one clear action.

Turns towards the camera · Opens a glowing box · Walks through heavy rain · Throws a cricket ball · Raises a glass bottle · Looks at the phone in disbelief

4. Where is it happening?

A quiet university library · A crowded Indian railway station · A premium modern gym · A futuristic city at night · A minimalist white studio · A dusty cricket ground at sunset

5. How should the camera move?

Slow push-in · Smooth tracking shot · Handheld camera · Camera orbiting the subject · Rapid zoom-out · Static locked camera · Dolly from left to right

Use one main camera movement per shot.

6. What should the lighting look like?

Soft morning light · Golden-hour sunlight · Dramatic side lighting · Neon blue and red · Harsh stadium lights · Warm indoor lighting · Moody low-key lighting

7. What visual style do you want?

Photorealistic · Cinematic advertisement · Documentary · Anime · Stop motion · Clay animation · Luxury product commercial · Vintage film · Futuristic sci-fi

8. What should the AI avoid?

"No text, no subtitles, no watermark, no distorted hands, no duplicate people, no sudden camera shake, no scene change."

Negative instructions reduce unwanted elements. They do not guarantee perfect results.

SECTION 06

Three copy-paste prompts

Use these as-is in Google Flow, or swap the subject and location to match your idea.

PROMPT 1: SCROLL-STOPPING REEL HOOK

Extreme close-up of a young Indian creator looking directly into the camera as the room suddenly freezes around him and hundreds of glowing AI interface cards appear behind his head, fast initial movement followed by a smooth slow camera push-in, dramatic yellow and blue lighting, realistic cinematic style, high contrast, strong visual surprise in the first second, vertical 9:16 composition, leave clear space near the lower centre for captions, no text, no logos, no watermark.

PROMPT 2: PRODUCT ADVERTISEMENT

Premium commercial shot of a black wireless headphone case placed on a reflective glass surface, the case slowly opens while glowing sound waves travel through the air, dark luxury studio, controlled camera orbit, soft rim lighting, realistic materials, shallow depth of field, cinematic product advertisement, vertical 9:16 composition, product remains unchanged throughout the shot, no hands, no text, no logos, no watermark.

PROMPT 3: CINEMATIC STORY SCENE

Wide cinematic shot of a university student walking alone through an empty college campus during heavy rain at night, backpack over one shoulder, reflections visible on the wet ground, camera slowly tracking behind him, warm lights glowing through classroom windows, emotional and mysterious atmosphere, photorealistic film look, natural body movement, vertical 9:16 composition, no extra people, no text, no watermark.

NOTICE THE PATTERN

Each prompt answers all eight questions from Section 5. Shot, subject, action, place, camera, lighting, style and restrictions. Copy the structure, not just the words.

SECTION 07

How to maintain character consistency

Character consistency is one of the hardest parts of AI video generation. This workflow makes it manageable.

1. **Create a master character image**

   Generate one clear image showing the face, hairstyle, clothes, body type, accessories and colour palette. Use this same image as the reference for every scene.

2. **Create a character description**

   Example: "Aarav is a 21-year-old Indian university student with short slightly messy black hair, brown eyes, an oval face and a lean build. He always wears an olive-green T-shirt, black trousers, white sneakers and a black backpack."

   Paste the same description into every relevant prompt.

3. **Keep one visual style**

   Do not make one scene photorealistic, the next animated and the third vintage, unless the style change is intentional.

4. **Generate one shot at a time**

   Short, focused shots are easier to control than complicated sequences.

5. **Reuse successful frames**

   When the character looks correct, take the final frame from that video and use it as the starting frame for the next generation.

6. **Create a continuity sheet**

   Record the character description, clothes, location, time of day, lighting, camera style, colour palette and props. This becomes your project's visual rulebook.

SECTION 08

Image to video: the better workflow for control

For advertisements and consistent characters, use this nine-step process.

1. Write the concept.
2. Divide it into individual shots.
3. Generate one still image for every shot.
4. Correct the images before generating video.
5. Upload each image into an image-to-video model.
6. Describe only the movement.
7. Generate two or three variations.
8. Select the best clip from every shot.
9. Join the clips in an editor.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Your **image prompt** controls appearance. Your **video prompt** should mainly control movement.

EXAMPLE IMAGE-TO-VIDEO MOTION PROMPT

The camera slowly pushes towards the subject. The subject looks up from the laptop and turns towards the camera with a surprised expression. Papers move gently from the breeze. Natural body movement, stable face, no scene change.

This is usually more reliable than repeating the full visual description.

SECTION 09

Tool list: free and paid

Every tool below has a real use case. You only need one generator and one editor to start.

Google Flow FREE + PAID

Best for: beginners, cinematic clips, references, transitions and short films.

Start here when: you want high-quality video without immediately paying.

Free users currently receive 50 credits daily. Veo 3.1 Lite uses 10 credits per generation for non-Ultra users. Flow also supports Ingredients to Video, Frames to Video, video extension and generated audio.

Runway LIMITED FREE + PAID

Best for: serious creators who want generation, editing, audio and several leading models in one workspace.

Start here when: you want more control and plan to produce videos regularly.

The free plan currently includes a one-time allocation of 125 credits. Paid plans provide access to models including Gen-4.5, Aleph, Veo, Kling and Seedance, plus video editing and audio tools.

Kling AI FREE CREDITS + PAID

Best for: human movement, action, realism and longer continuous shots.

Start here when: your scene contains significant character or camera movement.

Promotes text-to-video, image-to-video, multi-shot storyboarding, character consistency and clips of up to 15 seconds, depending on the model and plan.

Pika FREE + PAID

Best for: social-media effects, transformations, short experiments and audio-driven character animation.

Start here when: you want something visually playful rather than a complete filmmaking system.

The current free plan includes 150 monthly credits. The Pikaformance feature can animate images to speak, sing or react to audio.

Adobe Firefly LIMITED FREE + PAID

Best for: Adobe users, advertisements, business content and multi-model access in one interface.

Start here when: you already use Photoshop, Premiere Pro or Adobe Express.

Offers limited free daily image, video and audio generations. Paid plans add monthly credits and access to Adobe's video model and selected third-party models.

Luma Ray CREDIT-BASED + PAID

Best for: cinematic visuals, creative experimentation and high-quality motion.

Start here when: you care more about visual style than producing large quantities cheaply.

Luma's current video system is called Ray. Ray 3.2 replaced older Ray and Dream Machine branding in June 2026.

MiniMax Hailuo LIMITED ACCESS + PAID

Best for: fast, economical short video generation.

Start here when: you want to test several short clips without premium-priced models.

Currently offers Hailuo 2.3 and Hailuo 2.3 Fast for short text-to-video and image-to-video generations, including six and ten-second options depending on the model.

VN Editor FREE

Best for: beginners, social videos, captions and mobile editing without a watermark.

Start here when: you want one simple mobile workflow for cutting and captioning reels.

Free on mobile and desktop. Handles trimming, speed ramps, captions and 9:16 exports for reels.

HeyGen FREE + PAID

Best for: AI presenters, talking avatars, translations, lip sync and faceless content.

Start here when: you need a person to speak a script rather than a cinematic scene.

The free plan currently allows up to three videos per month with limited access to premium avatar features.

Synthesia FREE + PAID

Best for: training videos, educational explainers, presentations and professional avatars.

Start here when: you are creating structured business or educational content.

Offers AI avatars, voices, templates and script-to-video tools. The current free offering allows up to ten minutes of generated video per month on the relevant free workflow.

DaVinci Resolve FREE + PAID STUDIO

Best for: professional editing, colour grading, audio and final video production.

Start here when: you want a powerful editor without a monthly subscription.

The free version supports common formats up to Ultra HD 3840×2160 at 60fps. The paid Studio edition adds the Neural Engine plus additional AI, effects and noise-reduction tools.

IMPORTANT SORA UPDATE

Many older AI-video guides recommend OpenAI Sora. The standalone Sora web and app experiences were discontinued on 26 April 2026. Do not build your current workflow around outdated Sora tutorials.

SECTION 10

Which tool should you choose?

CHOOSE	IF
Google Flow	You are a complete beginner and want usable free daily generations
Runway	You want an all-in-one professional creative workspace
Kling	Your video contains people, actions or complex movement
Pika	You want unusual effects and social-media experiments
Adobe Firefly	You already use Adobe applications
HeyGen or Synthesia	You need a speaking AI presenter
VN Editor	You want the simplest mobile editing workflow
DaVinci Resolve	You want professional editing and colour control for free

> **DO NOT SUBSCRIBE TO FIVE TOOLS AT ONCE**
>
> Start with one generator and one editor.

Recommended starter stacks

STACK	TOOLS
Beginner stack	Google Flow + VN Editor
Free professional stack	Google Flow + DaVinci Resolve
Paid creator stack	Runway + VN Editor or DaVinci Resolve
Avatar stack	HeyGen or Synthesia + VN Editor

SECTION 11

Audio, voice and music

A video can look impressive and still feel weak because of poor sound.

Your final video may need: voiceover, dialogue, background music, environmental sounds, transition sounds, impacts and risers.

Best beginner method

1. Generate the visual clip.
2. Record the voice separately.
3. Add the voice inside VN Editor or DaVinci Resolve.
4. Add background music at a lower volume.
5. Add only the sound effects that support visible actions.

> **TWO RULES**
>
> Do not cover every second with loud effects. And for scripted dialogue, generating visuals first and adding a separate voice usually gives more control than depending on model-generated speech.

SECTION 12

How to edit the final video

1 **Place clips in story order**

Hook → Problem → Reveal → Proof → Payoff → Call to action

2 **Remove weak frames**

Delete empty pauses, distorted movements, unnecessary beginnings, unnatural endings and repeated actions.

3 **Add sound**

Place the voice first, then music and effects.

4 **Add captions**

Use large readable text. Keep each caption chunk short. Highlight only important words. Do not cover the face. Keep important text away from the Instagram interface.

5 **Colour match the clips**

AI generations may have different colours. Adjust exposure, contrast, temperature and saturation so the shots feel like one video.

6 **Export**

SETTING	VALUE FOR INSTAGRAM REELS
Resolution	1080 × 1920
Aspect ratio	9:16
Frame rate	30fps
Format	MP4
Codec	H.264
Audio	AAC
Safe zone	Keep important graphics above the bottom 20% of the screen

SECTION 13

The biggest beginner mistakes

Nine mistakes that waste credits, time and motivation.

1. Trying to generate the full video in one prompt

Create individual shots instead.

2. Adding too many actions

One clip should usually contain one subject, one primary action and one camera movement.

3. Starting with the most expensive model

Test the concept using Lite or Fast models first.

4. Generating text inside the video

AI-generated text can still be inconsistent. Add titles, captions and logos during editing.

5. Ignoring the first frame

On social media, the first second matters more than the final cinematic shot.

6. Changing the character description

Reuse the same character description and reference image.

7. Upscaling every generation

Only upscale the final selected clips.

8. Depending entirely on AI audio

Generate or record important dialogue separately when accuracy matters.

9. Publishing the raw generation

Editing, sound design, captions and pacing are what turn an AI clip into actual content.

SECTION 14

The professional workflow

Once you understand the basics, use this three-phase process for every project.

Phase 1: Pre-production

- Define the audience
- Write the concept
- Create a script
- Divide the script into shots
- Select the visual style
- Create character and product references

Phase 2: Production

- Generate reference images
- Animate each image
- Create multiple variations
- Save successful prompts
- Maintain character and style consistency
- Generate extra transition shots

Phase 3: Post-production

- Select the strongest clips
- Edit the story
- Record voiceover
- Add sound effects and music
- Add captions and graphics
- Match the colours
- Remove generation errors
- Upscale only where required
- Export for the intended platform

SECTION 15

Your first practice project

Create a 15-second reel with three shots. Do this before buying anything.

CONCEPT

A student discovers an AI tool that changes how he studies.

1. **Shot 1: Hook**

   The student opens a laptop and a bright light fills the library.

2. **Shot 2: Reveal**

   AI notes, diagrams and flashcards rise from the laptop screen.

3. **Shot 3: Payoff**

   The camera pulls back to show the student studying while the AI organises everything around him.

Generate each shot separately. Then add this voiceover:

> **VOICEOVER**
>
> "Most students use AI to get answers. Very few use it to build a complete study system."

Add captions, sound effects and music in VN Editor or DaVinci Resolve.

This one project teaches you

Prompting · Shot planning · Image-to-video · Camera movement · Continuity · Editing · Sound design · Exporting

SECTION 16

Final checklist before publishing

Run every video through this list. Print it if you have to.

- [ ] Does something interesting happen in the first second?
- [ ] Is the main subject visible immediately?
- [ ] Does every shot have a purpose?
- [ ] Are the face and hands usable?
- [ ] Is the character consistent?
- [ ] Are the movements natural?
- [ ] Is the text readable?
- [ ] Is the voice clear?
- [ ] Is the music lower than the dialogue?
- [ ] Have I removed unnecessary pauses?
- [ ] Is the video exported in the correct aspect ratio?
- [ ] Do I have permission to use every uploaded face, voice, logo and copyrighted asset?

REMEMBER

AI can generate the footage. Your ideas, judgement, editing and storytelling are what make the video worth watching.

THE FOOTAGE IS AI.
THE TASTE IS YOURS.

You now know the full pipeline. Idea, shot list, references, clips, sound, edit, export. Make one clip today. That is how every creator starts.

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